

Unit 6 Part B — Writing a One-sided Argumentative Essay

1. Purpose & example questions

Purpose

- To express your opinion on a **controversial** issue, arguing either for or against it
- Target audience — **students** (on the school newsletter), the **general public** (on newspapers and technology magazines)

Example questions

- *Social media does more harm than good to teenagers.*
- *Should schools ban AI chatbots from the classroom?*
- *Is the internet making us less able to concentrate?*

2. Planning your essay

Title	Choose ONE of three patterns: (1) Issue + verdict — <u>Social Media: More Harm Than Good</u> (2) Question — <u>Is Social Media Doing More Harm Than Good?</u> (3) Call to action — <u>Why We Must Rethink Social Media</u>
Introduction	1. Hook — one striking line, figure, image or short question <i>The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media.</i> 2. Narrow the focus — link the issue to the audience <i>Social media is now ubiquitous and it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another.</i> 3. Stance — ONE side, in one sentence <i>I firmly believe that ... / It is undeniable that ...</i>
Body paragraphs 1 & 2	1. Topic sentence — a signpost + the argument itself <i>First and foremost, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health.</i> 2. Explain — build a cause-and-effect chain (X → Y → Z) <i>Platforms are designed to reward comparison, so users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's lives, and they are encouraged to measure their own against them.</i> 3. Example — Findings / Real-world case / Typical process / Hypothetical scene <i>Findings — "According to the US Surgeon General's 2023</i>

	<i>advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety."</i> <i>Real-world case — France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a "digital pause", requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. (Another: in November 2024, Australia legislated a minimum age of sixteen for social media accounts.)</i> <i>Typical process — Consider what happens when the app is opened for a five-minute break: the feed fills with classmates' holidays and prizes, an ordinary evening is set beside them, and self-doubt follows.</i> <i>Hypothetical scene - Imagine a Form 5 student who opens the app 'just for five minutes' before bed: two hours later the essay is untouched and the alarm is set for six.</i> Never write these (a marker spots them instantly) • invented names ("my friend Jason", "a Form 5 student called Mary") • invented percentages ("87% of students") 4. Round off — echo your topic sentence <i>Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates the anxiety that many teenagers already carry.</i>
Body paragraph 3 (counter-argument & rebuttal)	1. Concede — state the other side briefly <i>Admittedly, ... / Some may argue that ...</i> 2. Rebut — a concrete reason why the objection fails <i>However, this argument overlooks the fact that ...</i> 3. Round off — re-affirm your stance <i>Put simply, the convenience is real but modest, while the harm compounds year after year.</i>
Conclusion	1. Restate the stance in NEW words — do not copy the introduction 2. Summarise your arguments in one line. 3. Final thought — a call to action.

3. Practice - Complete the following writing plan	
Question: <i>Social media does more harm than good to teenagers.</i> Your stance: <i>Negative — argue that social media does NOT do more harm than good to teenagers.</i> Blue = the Negative side — this plan argues AGAINST the statement above. <i>It answers the same question as Section 4, but from the opposite side. Use ONE example type per body paragraph: findings → real-world case → typical process.</i>	
Title	Issue + verdict: Social Media: More Friend Than Foe Also acceptable: Is Social Media Really the Enemy? (question) · Why We Must Stop Blaming Social Media (call to action)
Introduction	Hook: for a teenager with nobody to talk to, a phone can be the one open door. Stance: I firmly believe that social media does not do more harm than good to teenagers.
Body paragraph 1	Social media strengthens friendship instead of weakening it. Findings — In 2022, the Pew Research Center found that 80% of American teenagers said social media made them feel more connected to their friends' lives, and 67% said it gave them people who could support them through tough times.
Body paragraph 2	Moreover, the benefits reach beyond friendship: the same platforms have made reading and learning social again. Real-world case — In 2021, US print book sales reached a record 825.7 million copies, and the industry tracker NPD credited TikTok's #BookTok community — teenagers recommending books to one another in short videos — with helping young adult fiction to its best year on record.
Body paragraph 3	Concede: critics are right that hours of scrolling can waste time and invite comparison. Rebut: the problem is how the tool is used, not the tool itself. Typical process — Consider what happens when the same app is used with a purpose: a student who loves coding joins a forum, strangers answer the questions at midnight, the work improves, and a hobby becomes a skill. Round off: Put simply, the platform is not the problem; the way it is used is.
Conclusion	Restate: social media is not the cause of teenage unhappiness; it reflects how we choose to use it. Summarise: it keeps lonely students connected and can mobilise help at a scale older media never could. Final thought: schools should teach judgement rather than issue bans, because the app will be in their pocket either way.

4. Sample writing
Question: You have read an article in a local technology magazine claiming that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. Write an essay for the magazine arguing for OR against this view. Support your view with

reasons and examples. (about 400 words)

BOLD = *persuasive language*

Underlined = *linking words and signals*.

Social Media: More Harm Than Good	Title
The average Hong Kong teenager now spends close to six hours a day on social media. That time could have been spent sleeping, revising or simply talking to family. Social media is now ubiquitous, and <u>although</u> it promises connection, it quietly reshapes the way young people see themselves and one another. I firmly believe that social media does more harm than good to teenagers. <u>First and foremost</u>, social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health. Platforms are designed to reward comparison, <u>so</u> users are constantly shown polished photographs of other people's holidays and achievements, and pushed to measure their own lives against them. The evidence is no longer in doubt: according to the US Surgeon General's 2023 advisory, adolescents who spend more than three hours a day on social media face double the risk of depression and anxiety. Day after day, this comparison erodes self-esteem and exacerbates anxiety — harm that is easy to miss <u>because it feels normal</u>. <u>Moreover</u>, the damage reaches beyond feelings into academic performance. Every notification leaves attention fragmented, making deep reading almost impossible to sustain. Late-night scrolling also delays sleep, which <u>in turn</u> undermines concentration in class. Governments have reached the same conclusion: France has restricted phones in its middle schools since 2018 and in 2024 trialled a "digital pause", requiring pupils to hand in their phones for the whole school day. When the loss is measured in attention and sleep, convenience is a poor defence. <u>Some may argue that social media keeps teenagers connected and gives them a voice they would otherwise lack. Admittedly, a group chat can help a class organise a project, and a niche interest may find community online. However, these benefits are superficial when set against the costs. Consider what happens when a group chat becomes a teenager's main company: the messages arrive all evening, every exchange stays on the surface, and real friendship is never attempted. A following built on 'likes' is rarely mutual support; at best, it is a short-lived substitute for friendship. Put simply, the convenience is real but modest, while the harm compounds year after year.</u>	Introduction • Hook • Stance Body 1 - Argument • Topic sentence • Explanation • Findings • Round off Body 2 - Argument • Topic sentence • Explanation • Real-world case • Round off Body 3 - Counter-argument • Concede • Rebut • Typical process • Round off Conclusion • Restate stance • Summarise arguments • Final

<u>In conclusion</u>, social media is not without value, yet its effects on teenagers' well-being, concentration and self-image plainly outweigh its benefits. Banning the technology would be counterproductive; the answer is a deliberate effort to curb the hours we spend online. If teenagers can learn to switch off, they will discover that the world beyond the screen deserves their attention. (408 words)	thought
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5. Language features — five reminders
Both examples in each pair say the SAME thing. BOLD = persuasive language. <u>Underlined</u> = linking words.

Reminder	✗ Poor example	✓ Upgraded example (from the sample)
Formal vocabulary no "super", "stuff", "a lot of things"	Social media <u>makes teenagers feel more worried</u> .	Social media exacerbates the anxiety teenagers already carry.
Passive voice ... be + past participle	Teenagers <u>always see</u> the perfect lives of other people on social media.	Teenagers are constantly exposed to polished images of other people's lives on social media.
Persuasive language (BOLD)	Social media is <u>bad</u> for students.	Social media is detrimental to teenagers' mental health. Fragmented attention makes deep reading almost impossible to sustain .
Linking words (<u>underlined</u>)	Social media is harmful. Students cannot concentrate.	Social media is harmful; <u>as a result</u> , students can no longer concentrate.
Avoid personal pronouns 'you'	You can see that phones are super bad for students' focus.	It is undeniable that over-reliance on smartphones undermines students' concentration.

6. Quick reference	
Introduce and take a stance	In recent years, ... has become ubiquitous. I firmly believe that ... It is undeniable that ...
Open the first argument	First and foremost, ... The most serious consequence of ... is ...

Add an argument	Moreover, ... Worse still, ... Equally worrying is ...
Give an example	For instance, ... According to + [source] + ([year]), ... Consider what happens when ...
Concede, then rebut	Admittedly, ... Some may argue that However, ... What this overlooks is ...
Conclude and end	In conclusion, ...